

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Landscaping and Grounds English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Landscape crew members, groundskeepers, lawn-service workers, and grounds assistants.

All properties, people, quantities, incidents, and service arrangements are fictional language practice, not horticultural, pesticide, equipment, irrigation, tree-work, safety, or property-law training. Do not infer plant treatments, application rates, pruning methods, site safety, or legal boundaries from these examples. Refer technical suitability, hazardous conditions, property questions, prices, and job changes to the responsible qualified people.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

access arrangement

The agreed way and time for workers to enter a property or service area.

bare patch

An area of lawn or planting bed where expected growth is absent.

clippings

Cut pieces of grass or other vegetation produced during grounds maintenance.

completion note

A job record distinguishing completed grounds tasks from any stated exceptions.

coverage area

The measured or specified surface area intended to receive a material.

debris removal

The collection and removal of specified loose waste material from the job area.

delivery quantity

The amount of landscaping material recorded as arriving for a job, with its unit stated.

exclusion

A task or location expressly left outside the agreed work.

finish standard

The agreed description of how the completed grounds work should look or be left.

flower bed

A defined planting area intended for flowers or other ornamental plants.

follow-up visit

A later appointment to review or complete specifically identified work.

hedge line

The visible outline or agreed shape of a row of closely grown shrubs.

irrigation zone

A defined section served by a particular part of an irrigation system.

material sample

A small example used to show a proposed material's appearance or type.

mulch

Material used as a surface layer over soil in landscape beds; suitability and application require qualified guidance.

no-work area

A specifically identified area excluded from work during the job.

outstanding item

A task or decision still unresolved at the end of the current visit.

property boundary

The limit separating properties; its legal position requires appropriate confirmation, not a worker's guess.

provisional date

A suggested date that has not yet become a confirmed appointment.

pruning request

A customer's proposed change to plant growth or shape that requires suitability and scope review.

recurring visit

A grounds-service appointment that repeats on an agreed schedule.

rescheduled visit

A replacement appointment confirmed after the original visit changes.

seasonal task

A grounds task scheduled for a particular season or period, subject to the job plan.

service area

The specified part of a property included in a grounds job.

service interval

The time between successive grounds-service visits.

site contact

The named person who answers access or job-location questions at a property.

site observation

A factual description of something noticed at the property, with location and time.

specimen plant

An individual plant treated as a distinctive feature of the landscape.

standing water

Water remaining visibly pooled on a surface.

walk-through

A joint review of the worked area to check completion against the agreed tasks.

weather delay

A change in planned grounds work caused by weather conditions affecting the job.

work order

The job record stating the grounds work requested or agreed for a visit.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Name what the visit includes

Today's work order includes ____.

____ is outside this visit's listed work.

Would you like the office to review ____ separately?

A recurring service does not automatically include every grounds task on every visit.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm the work order: compare the customer's request with the job record

define the service area: name the included part of the property

flag an extra request: separate new work from the existing booking

check the recurring schedule: verify which tasks happen on which visits

Keep uncertain boundaries explicit

Our confirmed work area ends at ____.

The status of ____ hasn't been established.

We can refer ____ while continuing with ____.

A fence, hedge, or informal statement may not establish the legal property limit. Practice referral, not boundary advice.

Word combinations in this lesson

confirm access with the site contact: verify entry arrangements

identify the no-work area: name the excluded location

query the boundary: ask for confirmation rather than infer ownership

preserve the agreed limit: keep work within the confirmed scope

Replace vague appearance words with a clear request

Which plant do you mean by ___?

Are you asking about ___ or ___?

I'll relay the desired appearance for ___ to review.

Clarifying a preference is not diagnosing plant health or prescribing pruning.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the desired appearance: explain the visual result being requested

identify the specimen plant: distinguish the individual plant concerned

confirm which bed: use a location rather than a vague direction

refer a pruning request: ask the qualified lead to review suitability

Explain what is paused and what is provisional

The lead has paused ___ because ___.

___ is provisional until ___ confirms it.

Your event is ___; I'll request an update by ___.

Relay the lead's decision and the actual booking status. Avoid declaring a site suitable yourself.

Word combinations in this lesson

report a weather delay: explain the changed visit status

offer a provisional date: identify a possible time without confirming it

review the service interval: check the gap created by a delay

confirm the revised visit: state the actual agreed replacement booking

Describe a symptom without naming a cause

I noticed ___ at ___ near ___.

I haven't established whether ___.

Could the lead review ___?

Location and timing make an observation useful. Do not turn a visible condition into technical diagnosis.

Word combinations in this lesson

report standing water: describe visible pooling and location

identify the affected zone: name the recorded irrigation area

separate observation from cause: avoid diagnosing an unconfirmed fault

refer a plant-health concern: pass an issue to a qualified person

Keep quantity and material mismatches separate

The order lists __; the delivery has __.

The sample is __, while the label says __.

Please check both __ and __.

A bag count does not establish coverage, and a similar-looking material is not automatically the agreed material.

Word combinations in this lesson

compare the material sample: check appearance against the agreed example

confirm the delivery quantity: state count and unit

flag a color difference: report a mismatch without approving substitution

check the coverage area: clarify which beds the estimate includes

Own the specific omission

You're right that __ remains within the listed area.

I'm sorry __ was missed.

I'll confirm how __ will be completed.

An apology can name the actual missed work. It need not imply that every requested extra was included.

Word combinations in this lesson

acknowledge a missed area: recognize a specific unfinished part

compare with the finish standard: check the result against the agreement

arrange a walk-through: review the actual area together

clarify debris removal: distinguish included cleanup from additional waste

Close a visit without closing unresolved work

__ is complete; __ remains deferred.

The customer requests __ before __.

__ owns the callback; the visit date is __.

A completion note can close today's visit while retaining an outstanding follow-up.

Word combinations in this lesson

separate completed from deferred: name each task's real status

hand over the customer request: preserve its exact scope

confirm the follow-up owner: identify who arranges the next response

close out the visit: report the actual completed work and exceptions

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Confirming the booked grounds work

Oak Court's work order includes front-lawn mowing and path leaf clearance. Resident asks for rear-hedge shaping. Hedges are excluded from today's booking; office can review a separate request, with no price or date confirmed.

Today's work order covers the front lawn and leaf clearance from the path. Rear-hedge shaping isn't included in this visit. Is that an additional request you would like the office to review? I'll keep the new hedge request separate from the booked work so we don't imply that its price or timing has already been agreed.

Try it again: The resident asks whether requesting the extra task guarantees it today. Distinguish request from booking.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Clarifying access and property limits

Customer asks for clearing beyond a rear fence, saying the strip is probably theirs. Work plan ends at the fence; ownership is unconfirmed. Worker can flag the request to the office but cannot decide the property boundary.

The current work plan ends at the rear fence. I understand you believe the strip beyond it belongs to you, but that boundary hasn't been confirmed for this job. We can continue with the agreed area and refer the additional strip to the office. I can't extend today's work on the basis of 'probably.'

Try it again: A neighbor offers permission verbally. Keep ownership and job authorization questions with the responsible office.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Clarifying appearance and plant requests

Customer says 'tidy the tall one' beside two plants near the entrance. They mean the rosemary beside the left flower bed, not the specimen magnolia. A qualified lead must review whether and how any pruning fits the job.

When you say 'the tall one,' do you mean the rosemary beside the left flower bed or the specimen magnolia near the door? Please identify the plant and describe the appearance you want. I can relay that request to the lead for review; identifying the plant doesn't by itself confirm a suitable pruning method or booking.

Try it again: The customer asks for a guarantee the plant will flower more. Refer that outcome question to the qualified lead.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Explaining a weather-related change

Lead has paused Cedar Court's planned outdoor work because of site conditions after rain. Office suggests Thursday, but crew availability is unconfirmed. Customer has an event Friday. Worker can relay the event and request a scheduling update by Wednesday noon.

The lead has paused today's outdoor work because of the site conditions after rain. Thursday is a provisional date, not a confirmed replacement visit. I understand your event is Friday. I'll pass that deadline to the office and request an update by Wednesday noon, without promising that all work can be completed before the event.

Try it again: Thursday becomes unavailable. Explain the change and ask the office for actual alternatives instead of defending the earlier suggestion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Reporting site observations without diagnosis

Worker sees standing water beside the east bed near irrigation zone 3 at 09:15. Cause is unknown; no system check has occurred. Customer asks if a pipe is broken. Grounds lead can arrange review.

At 09:15 I noticed standing water beside the east bed near zone three. I haven't checked the irrigation system, so I can't say a pipe is broken or identify the cause. I'll report the location and time to the grounds lead and ask for a review. The observation is confirmed; the explanation is not.

Try it again: A neighbor says it always happens after rain. Attribute that report without treating it as a verified cause.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Checking materials and requested quantities

A job lists eight bags of dark mulch for the front beds. Delivery has six bags; the label describes natural brown. Customer's approved sample was dark. Worker cannot approve substitution or promise coverage; office will query supplier.

The job lists eight bags of dark mulch for the front beds. Six bags arrived, and their label says natural brown. We have both a quantity difference and a material-description difference. Could the office check those against the approved sample and supplier order before we describe this delivery as matching the job?

Try it again: The supplier calls brown 'close enough.' Keep the substitution decision with the responsible office and customer.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Responding to finish and cleanup concerns

Customer says path cleanup was incomplete after today's front-lawn visit. Worker can see clippings beside the front steps, within the listed cleanup area. Rear patio is excluded. Lead can organize the missed front cleanup; no wider task is agreed.

You're right that clippings remain beside the front steps, which are part of today's listed path cleanup. I'm sorry that area was missed. I'll ask the lead to arrange completion of that specific cleanup and confirm the plan with you. The rear patio is a separate request, so let's keep it distinct from this missed task.

Try it again: The customer says an apology means all cleanup is free. Do not invent prices or decide the separate request.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Handing over unfinished grounds work

At Pine Court, front-path leaves are cleared. Rear-bed review was deferred by the lead; no planting or diagnosis was done. Customer requests a callback about that bed before Friday. Office contact Ava owns scheduling; a visit date is not booked.

The front-path leaf clearance at Pine Court is complete. The rear-bed review remains deferred; no planting or diagnosis was carried out there. Ava, the customer requests a callback before Friday about that bed. Please take the scheduling follow-up and confirm the callback arrangement. The request should not be recorded as a booked return visit yet.

Try it again: The next crew sees 'visit complete.' Explain which task is complete and what the office still owns.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All properties, people, quantities, incidents, and service arrangements are fictional language practice, not horticultural, pesticide, equipment, irrigation, tree-work, safety, or property-law training. Do not infer plant treatments, application rates, pruning methods, site safety, or legal boundaries from these examples. Refer technical suitability, hazardous conditions, property questions, prices, and job changes to the responsible qualified people.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Grounds Maintenance Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/building-and-grounds-cleaning/grounds-maintenance-workers.htm>

OSHA: Landscape and Horticultural Services Overview

<https://www.osha.gov/landscaping>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Landscaping and Grounds English

Professional audience: Landscape crew members, groundskeepers, lawn-service workers, and grounds assistants

Scope: All properties, people, quantities, incidents, and service arrangements are fictional language practice, not horticultural, pesticide, equipment, irrigation, tree-work, safety, or property-law training. Do not infer plant treatments, application rates, pruning methods, site safety, or legal boundaries from these examples. Refer technical suitability, hazardous conditions, property questions, prices, and job changes to the responsible qualified people.

Lesson 01: Confirming the booked grounds work

Original fictional case: Oak Court's work order includes front-lawn mowing and path leaf clearance. Resident asks for rear-hedge shaping. Hedges are excluded from today's booking; office can review a separate request, with no price or date confirmed.

Language workshop: Name what the visit includes

Communication goal: Clarify an extra task without dismissing the customer's request.

Language guidance: A recurring service does not automatically include every grounds task on every visit.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Today's work order includes _____. / _____ is outside this visit's listed work. / Would you like the office to review _____ separately?

Vocabulary: work order: The job record stating the grounds work requested or agreed for a visit. / service

area: The specified part of a property included in a grounds job. / exclusion: A task or location expressly left outside the agreed work. / recurring visit: A grounds-service appointment that repeats on an agreed schedule.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Resident: you assumed a regular grounds visit included the hedge; ask for a separate review.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The resident asks whether requesting the extra task guarantees it today. Distinguish request from booking.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Today's work order covers the front lawn and leaf clearance from the path. Rear-hedge shaping isn't included in this visit. Is that an additional request you would like the office to review? I'll keep the new hedge request separate from the booked work so we don't imply that its price or timing has already been agreed.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT